back to the Tablighi returnees. Due to the panic and fear of the unknown disease and a perception being built up in the media, folks began to blame the Tablighi Jamaat as the group responsible for spreading the virus in the country. A war of words between the Kejriwal government in New Delhi and police officials, where the former blamed the cops for not being able to get the building vacated and the latter releasing videos proving the actions they had taken was putting even more focus on the role of the group in the speed of transmission of the virus in the early days.[26]

The Markaz officials were of the opinion that after the prime minister announced complete lockdown of the country, the missionaries did not know how to return to their home towns.[27] While the massive manhunt to track down the Tablighi attendees, who had by now spread out to over 19 states, was being undertaken countrywide, the videos of sermons posted by the leaders in the Nizamuddin markaz were outright anti-science and in violation of government orders. In one such released tape (later taken down) but showcased on prime-time news, the chief leader of the Tablighi cult, Ameer Maulana Saad, is heard saying, 'Don't pay heed if they (the government) ask us to lock down mosques. They want us to stop praying in mosques. Allah is punishing us for abandoning mosques. We shouldn't pay heed even if doctors advice not to pray in mosques.'[28] For a society in anger, living in total lockdown akin to blackouts during war, a group of people (regardless of religion) in such abhorrent disobeyance of the law, led to heightened communal tensions. This disharmony was in full display around the Nizamuddin neighbourhood in Delhi. The city had only a couple months ago witnessed ugly communal riots.[29]

Reports from the police indicated that despite repeated urges to vacate, the jamaatis were not yielding; they weren't letting police personnel inside the premises either. However, the jamaatis defended themselves saying that they didn't have the required travel passes and permissions.[30] The situation was very tense. At the PMO, Intelligence had begun to come in that stone pelting and violence was on the verge of breaking out. To avert the violence, the government decided that it would be best to peacefully solve the problem versus using any kind of force through the army or the police to evacuate the masjid. Although the prime minister carries a reputation of being a tough administrator from his Gujarat days, he is also known to have a way with words to on-board all communities in times of crisis. For this,